

Aadhaar — The Linked Citizen at Maximum Scale

India deep-dive: the world's largest biometric ID, the law that shaped it, and the people it has failed

Public-interest research from public sources. Compiled 6 June 2026. Confidence flagged. Where harms are documented by campaigns or press rather than official admission, that is stated. Not a legal opinion.

Why Aadhaar matters to the wider story: it is the consent-free linked state taken to its limit — ~1.4 billion people on one biometric key, seeded across welfare, tax and banking. It is where the abstract risk becomes concrete: **real exclusion, real deaths, real surveillance architecture** — and a real court that pushed back. It is both the warning and, partly, the model for how to rein it in.

1. What it is, and the scale (**CONFIRMED**)

- **Aadhaar** is a **12-digit unique ID** issued by **UIDAI** (Unique Identification Authority of India), a statutory body under the Ministry of Electronics & IT.
- **~1.43 billion** Aadhaar numbers generated (≈ 142.76 crore as of Sept 2025); **>99.9% of adults** — the **largest biometric ID system on Earth**.
- **Biometrics held:** a photograph, **ten fingerprints, two iris scans**, plus face authentication (added 2018) — stored in a centralised **Central Identities Data Repository (CIDR)**. (*Sources: UIDAI; Wikipedia/Aadhaar.*)

2. What gets linked — the architecture (**CONFIRMED core; profiling ASSERTED**)

Aadhaar is designed as a **universal linking key**: the number is "seeded" into other databases so records across services resolve to one person — subsidies, **PAN (income tax)**, bank accounts, SIM cards, pensions, school enrolment, and more. - **State Resident Data Hubs (SRDH):** states built resident databases using Aadhaar as the linking key, enabling what critics describe as **"360-degree profiles."** (*Reported/ASSERTED — sourced to security researchers and advocacy, not official confirmation.*) - The central design intent: **one identity, queryable across domains** — which is exactly the cross-domain linkage at the heart of this whole investigation, but **person-facing and operational**, not just statistical.

3. The legal basis & the Supreme Court reckoning (**CONFIRMED**)

- **Aadhaar Act 2016** ("Targeted Delivery of Financial and Other Subsidies, Benefits and Services") is the statutory basis. It was **passed as a Money Bill** — bypassing the upper house — which became a central controversy.
- **Puttaswamy I (2017):** a 9-judge bench held **privacy is a fundamental right** under Article 21 — the foundation for everything after.
- **Puttaswamy II / the Aadhaar judgment (26 Sept 2018):** a 5-judge bench, **4:1, upheld Aadhaar's core constitutionality but read it down:**
- **Section 57 struck** — private companies can **no longer compel** Aadhaar (the court warned it enabled "commercial exploitation ... without consent" and **profiling**).
- **Mandatory bank-account linking (PMLA Rule 9) and SIM/mobile linking struck** — failed the proportionality test, no legislative backing.
- **Aadhaar-PAN (tax) linking upheld**, and **Section 7** (Aadhaar may be required for subsidies/benefits) upheld.
- **Justice D.Y. Chandrachud's dissent** called the Money-Bill route a "fraud on the Constitution" and warned explicitly of the surveillance risk — now one of the most-cited privacy dissents in the world. (*Sources: Supreme Court Observer; Privacy International; SFLC.in.*)

4. The human cost — exclusion (**DOCUMENTED by campaign & press; flagged as such**)

This is the part that turns the abstraction into bodies. When biometric authentication **fails** — a worn fingerprint, no connectivity, a seeding error — eligible people are **denied food rations and entitlements**. - The **Right to Food Campaign** has documented **~57 starvation deaths across nine states since 2015, at least 19 directly linked to Aadhaar** authentication/denial. (*Reported by the campaign and*

Indian press — EPW, Scroll — not official government figures.) - Named cases widely reported: **Santoshi Kumari (11, Jharkhand, 2017)** — died after the family's ration card wasn't linked to Aadhaar; **Lukhi Murmu (30, Pakur)** — denied rations after the point-of-sale machine failed to authenticate her biometrics; **Ruplal Marandi (60, Deoghar, 2017)** — family denied rations two months after authentication failed. - The pattern: officials and ration shops **demand biometric authentication even where it meant denying food to eligible people.** (*Sources: Scroll.in; Economic & Political Weekly; Right to Food Campaign.*) **This is the linked, consent-free state failing the most vulnerable — not in theory, in practice.**

5. Breach & surveillance concerns (*reported*)

- **January 2018 — The Tribune investigation:** reporters obtained login credentials being sold for ₹500 granting access to demographic details of Aadhaar holders in ~10 minutes. UIDAI **initially denied** it and **filed a complaint against the journalist** rather than fixing it first — itself a scandal.
- The WEF Global Risks Report / Avast characterised Aadhaar-related exposure as among the **largest data breaches** globally.
- **Surveillance concern:** because Aadhaar can resolve a person across service domains, critics warn it enables **tracking across domains** and the substrate for an "oppressive surveillance state." (*ASSERTED — capability/critique, sourced to researchers and advocacy; not a finding of current mass operational surveillance.*)

6. The fair counter-case (*must be stated*)

- **Real benefits:** Aadhaar **de-duplicated welfare rolls** (removing ghost/fake beneficiaries), enabled **direct benefit transfers** that cut leakage, and drove **financial inclusion** (bank accounts, mobile money) for hundreds of millions. The government cites large fiscal savings.
- **The court worked:** Puttaswamy is a genuine example of a constitutional democracy **constraining** the linked state — striking private and mandatory uses, affirming privacy as fundamental.
- **The harm is partly implementation, not only design:** much exclusion stems from **demanding biometric auth where the law didn't require it**, poor connectivity, and seeding errors — fixable failures, though that is cold comfort to the families.

7. The honest bottom line on India

1. **Scale unmatched:** ~1.4 billion people, one biometric key, seeded across the state.
2. **Consent-free by design**, on a statutory basis — the now-familiar pattern, but **operational and person-facing**, not merely statistical.
3. **The harm is real and documented:** exclusion deaths (reported, not officially admitted), a serious breach, denied entitlements — the clearest present-tense cost in this entire survey.
4. **But it is also the case for hope:** India's Supreme Court **pushed back hard** — proof the linked state *can* be constrained when there's a privacy right and a court willing to enforce it.
5. **The lesson for the wider story:** Aadhaar is what the consent-free linked citizen looks like at full scale and full stakes — *and* what democratic resistance to it looks like. Both halves are true; tell both.

8. Sources

UIDAI (official) · Wikipedia/Aadhaar · Supreme Court Observer (Puttaswamy judgment) · Privacy International · Software Freedom Law Center India · Scroll.in (exclusion deaths) · Economic & Political Weekly (Aadhaar failures) · Right to Food Campaign · The Tribune (2018 breach) · WEF Global Risks Report / Avast. *Death tolls and 360-profile claims are campaign/press/researcher-sourced and flagged as reported, not official.*